

CARNIVORES

Predominantly meat-eaters, carnivores have a body that is adapted for hunting and their teeth are specialized for grasping and killing prey.

The first known carnivore fossil dates to 55 million years ago. They were small, tree-dwelling, rather cat-like mammals, but their descendants, which include some of the largest predators on earth, display a range of forms and lifestyles. The order Carnivora ranges in size from the least weasel, 26 cm (10 in) long, to the southern elephant seal, which measures up to 5 m (16 ft) from nose to tail. The order includes the world's fastest land animal, the cheetah, and the famously idle giant panda. Carnivores are naturally present on every continent except Australia, where they have been introduced by man. They are not restricted to dry land – the 34 species of seal, sea lion, and walrus are more at home in the oceans.

CHARACTERISTICS

With such diversity, it can be difficult to ascertain what the animals of this order have in common. The most important shared characteristic of the

group is their teeth. All members of Carnivora have four long canine teeth and a distinctive set of cheek teeth known as carnassials, which are modified for cutting meat. The sharp edges of the carnassials work like a pair of scissor blades when the animal opens and shut its jaws.

Most carnivores eat at least some meat, but few are exclusively carnivorous. Several species, such as the foxes and raccoons, are omnivores, eating a wide range of plant and animal foods. One species, the giant panda, is almost completely herbivorous, with a diet consisting mainly of bamboo.

SOLITARY OR SOCIAL

Carnivores may lead solitary lives, like most weasels and bears, or be highly social, like wolves, lions, and meerkats. Animals in the latter category live in highly organized co-operative groups, sharing responsibility for hunting, rearing young, and protecting their territory. Seals and sea lions are generally colonial during the breeding season, when they are obliged to return to dry land to mate and give birth; some species gather in hundreds or even thousands on favoured beaches.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	CARNIVORA
FAMILIES	16
SPECIES	288

DEBATE

PINNIPED OR CARNIVORE?

Taken at face value, it seems unlikely that the aquatic seals, sea lions, and walruses, known as pinnipeds from the Latin for “web-footed”, could belong to the same group as weasels and wildcats. But the structure of their skull and teeth, and the information coded in their DNA tells a different story. Pinnipeds have limbs modified for swimming, but – unlike whales – they are not wholly aquatic and must return to land in order to breed. Fossil and molecular evidence suggests that seals, sea lions, and the walrus share a common bear- or weasel-like ancestor, which diverged from the other carnivores about 23 million years ago.

DOGS, FOXES, AND RELATIVES

The Canidae are medium-sized, long-legged mammals, most of which have a bushy tail and erect ears. They are swift, intelligent predators, though most also eat plant foods. The highly social grey wolf is the ancestor of the domestic dog, a species domesticated by humans over 14,000 years ago, and now hugely varied in size and form.



50–75 cm
20–30 in

ARCTIC FOX
Alopex lagopus

This sturdy fox lives in the world's northernmost regions. Its variable colour forms include snowy white.

short,
pointed face



45–60 cm
18–23½ in

yellowish
white underside

BLANFORD'S FOX
Vulpes cana

A strictly nocturnal species, this fox inhabits steppe country of the Arabian Peninsula and the Middle East. It feeds upon invertebrates and fruits.

BENGAL FOX
Vulpes bengalensis

This agile, omnivorous fox inhabits open country in Nepal and India. Pairs remain together from year to year and rear several litters together.

39–57 cm
15½–22½ in



KIT FOX
Vulpes macrotis

Found in the S.W. USA, the kit fox is an efficient digger. Families live in burrows with up to 20 entrances.



48–52 cm
19–20½ in

CORSAC FOX
Vulpes corsac

A social, pack-dwelling animal of the Asian steppes, the Corsac fox is an opportunistic hunter of small animals. It also eats vegetable matter.



38–80 cm
15–32 in

large ears